LIN7209 – Syntax

Reconstruction

Adèle Hénot-Mortier (based on David's original materials)

09/12/2025

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Plan for today

- Review Principle A and see cases in which it does not seem to work as expected; propose reconstruction as a fix.
- Review other cases in which reconstruction appears to be needed.

A closer look at Principle A

Principle A

- Anaphors must be **locally bound**.
- Binding is C-Command and coreference.
- A node C-Commands exactly everything its sister (strictly) dominates.
- Coreference is established by a successful coindexation (respecting Φ-features etc.).

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Successes of Principle A

(1) a. Alice$_1$ drew a picture of herself$_1$.

b. * Herself$_1$ drew a picture of Alice$_1$.

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Initial issues with Principle A

- The following sentences are expected to check Principle A (why?)

(3) * That girl$_1$, herself$_1$ likes. Topicalization

(4) * Herself$_1$ likes every girl$_1$. (Quantifier raising)

(5) * Which girl$_1$ did Anson persuade herself$_1$ that David met?
wh-movement

- Solution:

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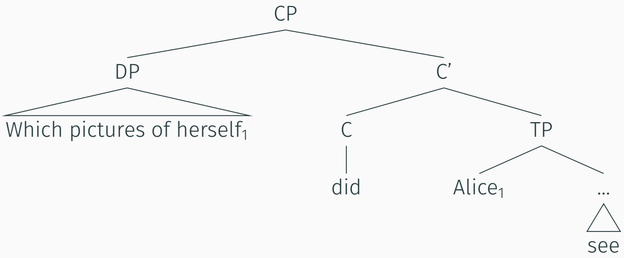
- A-Binding is binding from an A-position.
- Principle A then states that **anaphors must be locally A-bound**.
- The sentences above then violate Principle A because their binders are in Spec-CP so cannot A-bind!

More problems

- The sentence below is expected to be * (why?)

(6) Which pictures of herself$_1$ did Alice$_1$ see?



Tentative solutions

(6) Which pictures of herself$_1$ did Alice$_1$ see?

- Maybe the data is incorrectly interpreted (e.g. *herself* is **not an anaphor**, Pollard and Sag 1992).
- Maybe Principle A could be restated so it captures the example (David and I don't know of anyone that has said this).
- Maybe **the structure is not what it appears to be, so that Principle A is met** (this is the standard solution).

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Rephrasing Binding

- We slightly update what it means for a DP to bind another DP.
- A DP α binds a DP β iff α and β are coindexed and α C-Commands β **or a trace of a phrase containing** β.
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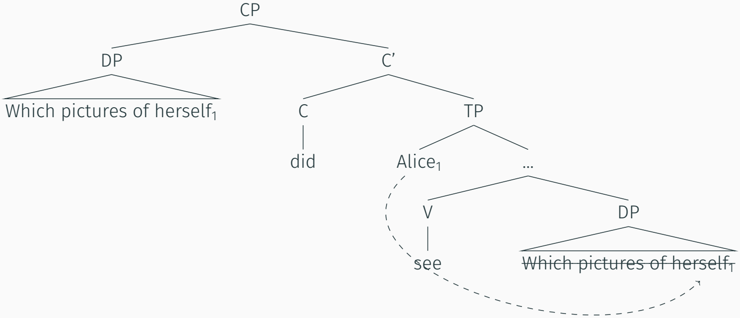

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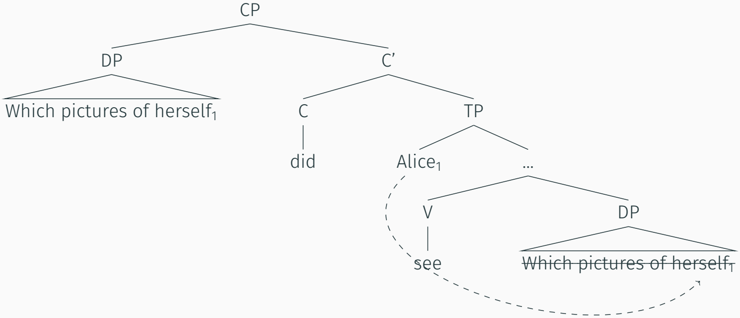

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- Then why is (9) fine?

(9) Alice$_1$ asked which pictures of herself$_1$ the boy had sold.

- For (9) to make sense, one must consider the binding configuration obtained **after *wh*-movement takes place**.
- But in (6), we had to consider the binding configuration ***prior* to *wh*-movement**...

(6) Which pictures of herself$_1$ did Alice$_1$ see?

When to bind, when to reconstruct?

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- Maybe in (6), Alice move covertly to a higher position, and this way we can always have binding *after wh*-movement? This may have bad consequences very quickly.
- Or, **we allow binding to apply prior to movement, optionally**, to “rescue” the sentence. This is called reconstruction, because it can be understood as the bindee being interpreted back where it was before movement.

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  - Quantifier-raise (**QR**) *every module* to the matrix to outscope *one student*.
  - Interpret *one student* lower than its surface position (**reconstruction**), and keep QR local (within the embedded clause).

An more elaborate argument for reconstruction cont'd

- Let's replace *convenor* by *his own mother*…

(11) One $student_1$ is expected by his_1 own mother [t_1 to pass every module with honors].

- Which reading(s) do we get now?

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- If the QR analysis were correct, we'd expect Reading 2 to be available here, because nothing would block *every module* from moving up.
- If the reconstruction analysis is correct, Reading 2 is out in (11)! This is because, if reconstruction happens, then *student* can no longer bind *his own*, leading to a Principle A violation. So **reconstruction is superior**.

Reconstruction for other cases

Movement as copy deletion: the Copy Theory

- Recall MOVE is RE-MERGE… so we expect **moved elements to be copied in the narrow syntax**!
- Phonological Forms normally **realize only one copy fully** (though remember the multiple/partial copy examples from last week!)
- Logical Forms (for semantics) are also subject to economy principles that regulate the deletion of superfluous copies, and may result in **stripped-down structures** like the following:

(6′) [Which ~~pictures of herself$_1$~~] did Alice$_1$ see [~~Which~~ pictures of herself$_1$]?

- Such structures undergo Determiner Replacement: the determiner in the lower copy gets replaced with *the*.[1]

(12) [which x] Alice$_1$ see [**the** x: x is pictures of herself$_1$]

[1] They also undergo Variable Insertion, which inserts an NP predicate $\lambda y.\ y = x$, s.t. x can be bound by Predicate Abstraction.

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Principle B

(13) a. Alice asked Mark to comb himself/*him.
b. Alice asked Mark to comb *herself/her.
c. Alice asked Sue to comb *himself/him.

- Pronouns and anaphors appear in **complementary distributions**.
- Principle B: a pronoun must be **A-free (not A-bound) in its local domain**.
- If a sentence contains a pronoun that is locally A-bound, then the sentence is ungrammatical.

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Principle C

(14) a. * Alice asked Mark to comb Mark.
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- Principle C: a referring expression (R-expression) must be A-free (not A-bound) *simpliciter* (no locality!).
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Reconstruction and Binding Principles B and C

(15) * Sarah asked how proud of herself the boy was.

- If reconstruction happens:

(16) * Sarah$_1$ asked [how ~~proud of herself~~] the boy was [~~how~~ proud of herself$_1$].
'Sarah asked what is the degree d s.t. the boy was proud to that degree d?'

- After reconstruction, the **anaphor is no longer locally bound**! Explaining *.
- For this to work one must however assume that **reconstruction of the restrictor of APs is obligatory**–converging evidence that it's the case.

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More cases of faulty reconstruction with Binding

- Again using APs forcing reconstruction...

(17) Principle B

a. * How proud of him is Anson?

b. * How proud of him did Karen say Anson was?

c. How proud of him did Anson say Karen was?

(18) Principle C

a. * How proud of Anson is he?

b. * How proud of Anson did Karen say he was?

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Bound variable Anaphora

(19) **No** woman denies that **she** has written a best selling novel.
Available: No woman *x* is s.t. *x* denies to have written a best selling novel.

(20) **Every** woman said **she** had met the Shah.
Available: Every woman *x* is s.t. *x* said *x* met the Shah.

(21) Did **any** woman say that **she** had met the Shah?
Available: is it the case that some woman *x* is s.t. *x* said that *x* had met the Shah?

(22) **Every** woman persuaded **her** son to organize **her** birthday party.
Available: Every woman *x* is s.t. *x* persuaded *x*'s (unique/salient) son to organize *x*'s birthday party.

(23) **Each** author decided that **she** should be at the signing.
Available: Each author *x* is s.t. *x* decided that *x* should be at the signing.

- Bound variable anaphora available for all quantifiers (even negative existentials!), under C-Command. No locality condition.

Bound Variable Anaphora cont'd

- Is C-Command necessary?

(24) **She** persuaded the Shah that **every** woman should be imprisoned.
~~Every woman x is s.t. x persuaded the Shah that x/every woman should be imprisoned.~~

(25) **She** didn't believe that I had been introduced to **any** woman.
~~Some woman x is s.t. x does not believe that I had been introduced to x.~~

(26) **She** expected that **each** author's book signing would be private.
~~Each author x is s.t. x expected that x's book signing would be private.~~

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(26) **She** expected that **each** author's book signing would be private.
~~Each author *x* is s.t. *x* expected that *x*'s book signing would be private.~~

- Bound readings require C-Command!

Bound Variable Anaphora cont'd

- Is C-Command necessary?

(24) **She** persuaded the Shah that **every** woman should be imprisoned.
~~Every woman *x* is s.t. *x* persuaded the Shah that *x*/every woman should be imprisoned.~~

(25) **She** didn't believe that I had been introduced to **any** woman.
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- **Bound readings require C-Command!**

Reconstruction for semantic binding

(27) The sybils decree that **no** man may love **his** closest relative.
Available: The sybils decree that no man x is s.t x may love x's closets relative.

(28) Which of **his** relatives did the sybils decree that **no** man may love?
Available: Which is the y s.t. did the sybils decree that **no** man x may love y, with y the relative of x?

- Bound reading only possible if *his relatives* reconstructs below *no man!*

(29) Which of his relatives forced the sybils to decree that no man was innocent?
~~Which is the *y* s.t. *y* forced the sybils decree that **no** man *x* is innocent, with *y* the relative of *x*?~~

- No bound reading if there's no reconstruction site below *no man.*

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Reconstruction for semantic binding (other examples)

(30) You persuaded the gallery that **every** artist liked **his** landscape pictures best.
Bound reading available.

(31) Which of **his** pictures did you persuade the gallery that **every** artist liked best?
Bound reading available.

(32) **His** landscape pictures persuaded the gallery that **every** artist likes flowers best.
No bound reading.

(33) Which of **his** pictures persuaded the gallery that **every** artist likes flowers best?
No bound reading.

Reconstruction for scope

(34) [Someone from New York]$_1$ is expected [t_1 to win the lottery].

- Two readings:
    - "High" reading of the existential: somebody from NY (say Jo) is s.t. Jo is expected to win the lottery. Scenario: we know for a fact that Jo bought 90% of all tickets.
    - "Low" reading of the existential: it is expected that someone from NY (could be Jo, could be Al...) will win the lottery. Scenario: we know for a fact that all NYers together bought 90% of the tickets: Jo bought 1%, Al 1% etc.
- We get the **high reading for free** from the surface scope.
- To get the low reading, reconstruction is the most plausible solution![2]

[2] Alternative: raise *expected* but it's not a quantifier over individuals...

Reconstruction for idiom interpretation

- Idioms are chunks that have a meaning vastly independent from the individual meanings of their parts.
- For that reason, idioms need to be interpreted as a chunk by the semantic module…

(35) "Take care"

a. Bill needs a lot of care. *But I'm sure Fred will take it of him.

b. How much care do you think Fred took of Bill?

- The idiom can be interpreted as such only if *care* is reconstructed near *took*!

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Summary

- Mostly reconstruction involves a cases where:
  - usually a certain **syntactic configuration** (e.g. C-Command, selectional locality) is needed to give a certain **semantic effect** (e.g. bound variable readings, scope, idiom interpretation);
  - but **that configuration is not available in the surface syntax**: so there's a syntax-semantics mismatch.
- We also get "reconstruction" for grammatical phenomena like case, though this is usually called **case connectivity**:

(36) HIM/*HE, I want to fire.

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